

03 COSTA MUERTA

ADVENTURE 3: COSTA MUERTA

BACKGROUND

Two weeks since the clinic siege. The droneware is out, the players are healing, Arasaka is consuming itself in an internal investigation that's spilling into the financial press. Lazard is still alive but increasingly cornered — Kojo's network reports he's been pulled from active duty, his accounts frozen pending audit. He is no longer pointing kill teams at the players. He is fighting to stay out of a corporate confessional booth.

The party still has two sealed droneware units. Sitting on them in Night City is a slow-motion mistake — every fixer in the city is starting to ask the wrong questions, and Trauma Team has been polite-but-curious about a depot job from the same week. **It's time to cash out and disappear for a stretch.**

Kojo has the lead. He's been quietly putting out the word south of the border, where the post-Corp-War legal vacuum means a sealed Arasaka R&D black box is a *trophy*, not a *risk*. Buyers have surfaced. The big one happens once a month: **Costa Muerta**, the offshore black-market biotech auction held on the Pacific rig city of **Nueva Costa**. Three days of credibility tour in Tijuana to land a sponsor, then helicopter to the rigs for auction night.

Core tension: This isn't a chase any more. The players are sellers, not prey. They have leverage, they have time, they have a road south — and they have two unmarked devices in a cooler that the most dangerous corporation on Earth would set the continent on fire to recover. The pressure now is *what they choose to do with that power*, and which faction they want carrying their card after this is done.

MAJOR NPCS

NPC	ROLE	DETAILS
Kojo Asante	Mats's fixer (recurring)	Brokered the southern route. Wants a piece for the introduction. Genuinely invested in the team now — they made him look good
Mateo Cruz	Aldecaldos waystation elder	Nomad warrior-priest type. Old, scarred, weighs people fast. Holds the keys to safe passage south of the Free Fire Zone
Don Bicho "El Cien Patas"	Raider warlord	Cybered-up highway predator running a convoy crew of ex-Arasaka security gone freelance. Hits anyone who can't afford the Aldecaldos toll
Comandante Castillo	Feudal border-checkpoint warlord	Ex-Federal officer who absorbed an abandoned border facility and runs it like a fiefdom. Reasonable if paid, brutal if not
Ofelia "Ofi" Castañeda	Kojo's Tijuana fixer	Runs the players' TJ safehouse and a flower-shop front in Zona Norte. Sharp, fast, doesn't sleep. Knows everybody who matters
Doña Esperanza Vargas	Los Curanderos matriarch	Ripperdoc syndicate boss. Older woman, missionary-cool, runs her empire from a former cathedral. Genuinely religious in a dark way
Reyna Solano "La Viuda"	Cyber-lucha star	Top of the Tuesday card. Sandevistan + monomolecular fan blade. Famous, broke, looking for a way out of the circuit
El Padre / El Hijo del Diablo	Cyber-lucha tag opponents	Reyna's tag partners. El Padre is a slam-grappler full-borg, El Hijo is a fire-breathing showman
Mr. Carlos Vega	Militech cutout	Smooth, ex-Special Forces, real name probably not Vega. Approaches the players after the lucha bout. Knows their NC file in unsettling detail
Tía Esmé Aldecaldo	Aldecaldos auction rep	Senior member of the actual Aldecaldo family. Wants drone-ware as a counter-corp deterrent for the Nomad nation. Pays in alliance more than cash
Iku Tanaka	"Independent" buyer (the trap)	Claims to represent a Pacific Rim medical conglomerate. Polite, precise, slightly off. Actually Arasaka counterintelligence under deep cover

NPC	ROLE	DETAILS
The Mole	Recurring from Adv 1–2	Brief background sighting on the road north. No interaction this session. Confirms they got out

CALENDAR

The auction is fixed. The journey is paced backwards from auction night.

DAY	EVENT
D-8	The Send-Off. Kitting up in Night City (cyberware, weapons, vehicles).
D-7	Kojo's final brief at Suki's. Convoy departs Night City at dusk.
D-6	Free Fire Zone. Don Bicho's highway ambush.
D-5	Aldecaldos waystation. Raider counter-attack.
D-4	Border crossing (La Frontera). Brief glimpse of the Mole heading north.
D-3	Arrive Tijuana. Ofelia's safehouse. Buyer landscape briefing.
D-2	La Lucha Cromada (cyber-lucha bout).
D-1	Buyer tour (Curanderos, Militech, Aldecaldos, Tanaka).
D-0	Helicopter transit to Nueva Costa. Costa Muerta auction.

RUNNING THIS ADVENTURE

Key DVs used (Cyberpunk RED scale): - Easy: **DV 11** (basic STREETWISE) - Standard: **DV 13** (Aldecaldos negotiations, border bribe persuasion, basic interference at ringside) - Difficult: **DV 15** (most buyer haggling, key AWARENESS reads on Tanaka, vehicle-pit counter-driving, NET architecture intrusion) - Hard: **DV 17** (Tía Esmé bond upgrades, deep reads on Tanaka, top-tier addendum upgrades, syndicate floor exception) - Very Hard: **DV 19** (catching the Arasaka watch logo on Tanaka, max Vega cash escalation)

Leveling between Adv 2 and Adv 3 (or at the close of Adv 3):

Run a flat leveling package per PC rather than counting IP for two infrequent sessions of damage and stress. Suggested package per PC: - **+1 to two skills** of the player's choice (their pick — usually role-defining ones) - **+1 Role Ability rank** if they're under Rank 6 (Fredrik's Combat Awareness, Mats's Operator, Digitz's Interface). If they're at Rank 5 already, this is a non-trivial jump - **Up to 5,000 eb of new cyberware or gear** (player's pick, GM approval): - Fredrik: Optical Camo cloak, Smartlink, or a serious melee weapon upgrade - Mats: Voice Stress Analyzer, Subdermal Armor (BODY+1), or a personal driver-AI - Digitz: a new program slot or two, Cybermodem upgrade, or Interface Plugs upgrade - **+1 Humanity recovery** for any character below max — they had two months off, and Fredrik specifically had therapy time

ADVENTURE STRUCTURE

Part 0: The Send-Off (Night City)

Two weeks of downtime have given the team time to heal, sit on the droneware, and — crucially — *spend money*. Past adventures have been frugal; the team is thin on chrome. With a 100k+ eb sale on the horizon, Kojo's 15k brokerage already on the table, and a credible road ahead, this is the moment to fix that.

Actions: - Kojo pitches the southern run at Suki's — sells them on the trip (no roll, exposition beat) - Negotiate Kojo's brokerage cut — **Mats's scene** as the Fixer. Default ask: **15k up front + 10% backend**. PERSUASION DV 13 → drop to 10k up front. DV 15 → drop to 5k up front. DV 17 → no cash up front, 12% backend instead. DV 19 → flat 10% backend, nothing up front. (He won't go below 10% on principle — he's putting his name on this)

Stop 1: Dr. Voss's Clinic — Cyberware Install

Tanaka's Fish Market, same back-room clinic from Adventure 2. The smell is exactly as bad as remembered. Udo is reading a different paperback now (a Russian historical fiction, dog-eared). Voss has changed nothing about the operating room — the same hardened blast door, the same shelving of components, the same near-pristine surgical theater that exists in the worst-smelling building in Night City.

She greets them politely. They are *even* — she does not owe them, they do not owe her. This is cash business now. But the warmth is real.

"You came back. Good. I have a new espresso machine."

She charges fair market rate. Standard install times are abbreviated for the team — Voss is fast, and she has favorable opinions of their nervous systems by now. Surgical downtime: 24-48 hours, which they spend recovering on the road during Day 1 of travel. Fredrik can sleep in the cargo van; Mats and Digitz can drive in shifts.

Suggested cyberware packages (each PC picks from their list — pick a few; Voss can install up to three pieces in one sitting before the convoy leaves). *The clean equipment lists are in the Voss's Menu handout at the back of this document — hand those to the players.*

For Fredrik (Solo — survivability + lucha + ranged): - **Subdermal Armor** (1,000 eb, +SP under clothes — stacks with armor) - **Big Knux** (100 eb, 2d6 brawling damage — *built for the lucha bout*) - **Pain Editor** (1,000 eb — ignore Seriously Wounded penalties; he was a near-death revive last session and this is the obvious answer) - **Smartgun Link** (1,000 eb — works with his Assault Rifle and SMG) - **Cybereye TeleOptics** (1,000 eb — extends ranged engagement range) - Optional: **Kerenzikov** (1,000 eb, +2 init) — if he wants more action economy

For Mats (Fixer — social armor + survivability + driving): - **Skinweave** (500 eb premium, +SP everywhere) - **Tactile Boost** (500 eb — useful in negotiations and driving) - **Armorjack Businesswear** (2,000 eb — premium SP 13 armored suit, looks like a tailored jacket) - **Personal AI Driver Interface** (2,000 eb — for the second vehicle; lets the car semi-autonomously evade while he focuses on shooting/talking) - **Cyberdeck (basic)** (1,000 eb — entry-level backup hacking; he's not Digitz but having his own deck for low-stakes work is operator-grade)

For Digitz (Netrunner — netpower + emergency survival): - **Cybermodem upgrade** (5,000 eb — top-shelf, +1 to Interface checks effectively) - **Extra Interface Plugs** (200 eb — second port set) - **Sandevistan** (1,000 eb — emergency speedware; netrunners go down fast in physical combat, this is the escape switch) - **Two new combat/utility programs** (~1,000 eb total — pick from the program list: Armor / Sword / Hellhound / DeckKRASH / Eraser) - Optional: **Subdermal Pocket** (500 eb — concealable storage for a spare deck or weapon)

Voss's parting note (Pain Editor warning to Fredrik only): *"This will let you keep fighting through wounds your body is telling you not to. Listen to your body anyway. The cyberware tells you 'fine.' It does not actually fix anything."* Genuine medical advice. Worth remembering at the table.

Stop 2: Kojo's Yard — Wheels

A walled compound behind a strip mall in Watson. Kojo runs a side business in clean vehicles — mostly stolen-and-laundered, but with full real paperwork. He has two main options on the floor (pick one) plus a bike for Fredrik.

The Main Vehicle — pick one:

1. **The Cargo Van.** Pre-Krash diesel, manual fallbacks (no remote-hijack surface), reinforced cabin, smuggler compartments in the floor for the drone coolers, firing slits cut into the rear doors. Slow but durable. Carries the Ricochet without anyone asking questions. SP 15, HP 50, Speed 5.
Free with the brokerage deal — Kojo is invested.
2. **The Sedan.** Sleek corpo-grade four-door, tinted glass, registered to a real shell company. Arriving at Tijuana buyer meetings in this is a status signal — Mats's Fixer instincts will love it. Faster and quieter than the van but a fraction of the cargo. The Ricochet does not fit cleanly; they'd have to break it down into the trunk and reassemble at the waystation. SP 11, HP 30, Speed 7. 25,000 eb.

GM Note — the tradeoff: Van is the tactical pick (Ricochet, cargo, durability, free). Sedan is the social pick (status at TJ buyer meetings, faster on the road, but Part 2's Ricochet defense becomes harder to set up — they're hauling crates out of a trunk under fire). Let them choose. Either choice is fine; the adventure flexes around it.

Plus — A Dirtbike for Fredrik. Per his lifepath, Fredrik has dirtbike experience. Kojo has a clean **Roadbike** ready (Cardinal Industries-style off-road model). Fast, agile, can flank in highway combat, can scout ahead, can leave a fight when the fight gets stupid. Speed 8, HP 25, SP 0. Changes road-combat dynamics — Fredrik becomes a mobile flanker rather than rear gunner. **Strongly recommended.** 12,000 eb.

Kojo's note on the bike: *"It's clean. Papers are real, plate is real, the engine has no remote anything. Don't crash it, but if you have to crash it, crash it at someone."*

Stop 3: Final Prep

Players choose their final loadout adjustments. Some likely additions:

- **Ammo and weapons restock:** All players to full ammo. Fredrik picks up a melee weapon upgrade if he didn't already (a real combat knife: 1,500 eb; a Cyber-katana: 5,000 eb — *good for ring fights and for the inevitable next CQB*)
- **Comms gear:** Three encrypted radios with mesh networking — Digitz handles. Lets them stay in contact across vehicles without going through Agent infrastructure
- **First aid:** Two MedTech kits, two cyber-recovery autoinjectors (each restores 1d6 HP per use, 500 eb each)
- **Climate gear:** Mexico desert kit, water reserves, sun-rated gear. *Atmosphere only* — no mechanical effect, but a player who packed it can describe themselves as "the one who thought ahead"

GM Note for leveling: This is also where the **skill / role / humanity-recovery package** from the GM Quick Reference lands. Players announce their skill picks, the new Role Ability rank, and any other +1s while they're at Voss's recovering. Resolve all paperwork before they leave Night City.

Part 1: The Long Road

Kojo's final brief. Suki's basement, the night of departure. Kojo has done the rest of the work — buyer list, safehouse in Tijuana with Ofelia Castañeda, contact protocol for the Aldecaldos at the Snake's Nest waystation, helicopter charter for the auction transit.

He hands Mats a small leather notebook. *"My read on the buyers. Don't lose this. Don't read it in front of anyone. And don't show me a copy."* Inside: handwritten notes on each TJ contact, with stars next to who Kojo would trust if it were his neck.

He takes his cut as negotiated (default 15k up front + 10% backend). Cheap given what he's putting on the line.

The convoy: Their main vehicle (van or sedan — Mats driving, Digitz shotgun, Fredrik recovering from chrome install in the back through Day 1) and Fredrik's roadbike (parked or trailered for the highway transit, ridden once they hit Free Fire Zone where flanking becomes useful). If they took the sedan, the Ricochet is in the trunk in pieces — they'll need a setup beat at the Snake's Nest before Part 2.

The route: Old I-5 south through what used to be San Diego County. The highway is technically intact — the off-ramps are not. Most of it is Free Fire Zone now, a 200-km stretch where the Aldecaldos and Snake Nation run informal toll waystations and *everyone else* is hostile.

GM Note: This part should run fast. 15-20 minutes max. The point is establishing the road, the mood, and getting them into the first combat.

The Highway Ambush (Don Bicho's Crew)

Late afternoon. Long shadows across the cracked highway. AWARENESS DV 13: cars coming in from side of road.

Behind them, two converted technicals pull onto the highway from a frontage road — light pickups with autocannons welded to the beds and chain-skirt armor on the doors. A third vehicle, a heavy tow-rig with a ram bumper, accelerates from a side road on the right.

This is **Don Bicho's** crew. He hits convoys that bypass the Aldecaldos toll. He doesn't bother negotiating — he assumes you couldn't afford it, which means he'll just take what you have and roll on.

Vehicle Combat (Cyberpunk RED Chase Rules):

Run as a chase scene with three pursuers. Goal: lose them or reach the **Snake's Nest** turnoff ~15 km south, where Aldecaldos guns will deter pursuit.

VEHICLE	TYPE	STATS	NOTES
Players' Van (<i>if chosen</i>)	Cargo van, reinforced	Speed 5, SP 15, HP 50	Slow, durable. Mats drives, Digitz shotgun. Firing slits in rear doors
Players' Sedan (<i>if chosen</i>)	Sleek corpo sedan	Speed 7, SP 11, HP 30	Faster, lighter, less durable. No firing slits — rear-seat fire means rolling windows down
Fredrik's Roadbike	Dirtbike	Speed 8, HP 25, SP 0	Fredrik deploys once contact starts. Off-road capable — can leave the highway
Don Bicho's Tow-Rig	Heavy ram vehicle	Speed 6, SP 18, HP 60, ram 4d6	Driven by Don Bicho. Wants to pit the main vehicle off the road
Technical #1 / #2	Light pickup with autocannon	Speed 7, SP 11, HP 35	Crew of 3 each. Gunner does 5d6, ROF 1. Outrun-fast but glass

Fredrik on the bike: Major tactical wrinkle. Fredrik can flank the technicals (their autocannons are mounted, slow to traverse), draw the tow-rig's attention away from the van, or scout ahead for the Aldecaldos sniper position. His Pop-up VHP cyberarm and bike mobility together make him a serious threat to the lightly-armored technicals. This is the first encounter where the bike *changes* the fight rather than just being scenery.

Don Bicho: SP 18 (chrome plating), HP 50, Heavy SMG 4d6, Cyberarm with extending mantis blades 3d6 melee. If pulled into a fight on foot, he's *delighted*. He's a sadist.

Encounter beats: - Round 1: Technicals open up at range. Driver check DV 13 to weave; failure means the gunner gets a clean shot - Round 2: Fredrik (or whoever is back-doors) can return fire from the cargo van. The van has firing slits cut into the rear doors — Kojo prepared for this - Round 3: Don Bicho closes for the pit maneuver. Counter-driving check DV 15, or take a 4d6 ram hit and a

difficult-terrain shake - Round 4-5: They should be closing on the Snake's Nest turnoff. As they crest a rise, two Aldecaldos snipers on a billboard ahead light up the technicals — first sniper round drops a gunner. Don Bicho pulls off. *"Until next time, gringos!"*

If the players want to stand and fight: Fine, but it's costly. Don Bicho will retreat once two of his three vehicles are critical. He doesn't die here — he becomes a recurring road threat for future returns south.

GM Note: The Aldecaldos extraction at the end is the *point* of this combat. Players learn (without being told): the Aldecaldos run this stretch, they noticed your trouble, they decided to help, and you now owe them an introduction. Don't lecture them on it — let the rescue do the talking.

Combat goal: Make vehicle combat feel different from everything in Adv 1–2. Fast, loud, mostly outside the van, with the urge to engage from cover. Fredrik can use Autofire here, which his sheet supports.

Part 2: The Snake's Nest (Aldecaldos Waystation)

A converted gas station and motel complex on the old I-5 corridor, ringed by junker trucks turned into walls. Smoke from grilling food. Children running. A working stage where someone is tuning an electric guitar. This place is *alive* in a way Night City rarely feels.

Arrival. The Aldecaldos receive them at the gate. The team of snipers that drove off Don Bicho is sitting on a roof, waving lazily. The players' van is escorted in. An old woman in welding goggles brings them water without being asked.

Meeting Mateo Cruz.

Mateo is the waystation elder. Mid-60s, snake tattoos up both arms, half-burned face, eyes that miss nothing. He receives them in a converted office with a wood stove and a chess set he's been playing against himself for ten years.

"You're carrying something hot. I don't need to know what. Kojo said you'd come, and Kojo doesn't lie to me. So we have business."

The favor he wants:

Don Bicho's crew has been growing. They hit the Snake's Nest three weeks ago — light probing attack, lost two raiders, retreated. Mateo's people repulsed it. But Bicho has been recruiting and he'll be back, harder, and probably tonight — because *he just lost face to your van*.

“You brought him here. You stay until he tries again. You help us put him down. Then I give you a clean passage south, an introduction at the border, and a letter to my cousin Esmé in Nueva Costa. That gets you in front of the right Nomad table.”

The Players’ Choice: - Accept: Aldecaldos goodwill, safe passage, an introduction to Tía Esmé (one of the four buyers) - // Lend him the ricochet - skill check to get idea, or natural? - Decline: They leave tonight, but the Aldecaldos won’t extend hospitality on the way back, and Tía Esmé won’t take their meeting cold

PERSUASION / CONVERSATION: Mats can negotiate additional terms (DV 15: Aldecaldos contribute fighters to the camp defense Mats can position; DV 17: they throw in fuel and a swap vehicle).

The Camp Defense (Abstracted)

Sundown. Mateo’s scouts report Don Bicho’s force closing — three technicals, a stolen mil-spec MRAP, ~20 raiders. Heavier than last time. He brought everything because the players just made him look weak on the highway.

Run this as a **single resolution beat**, not a full combat. The highway chase already filled the vehicle-fight quota; save the table’s combat energy for the auction.

Setup beat (~5 min of tactical talk). Players choose: - **Ricochet placement** — north highway approach (open ground, 400m fire lane), south wash (flanking cover), or split between both (-4 effectiveness, doubled coverage) - **Where each PC anchors** — Fredrik on the wash with his bike for mobility? Mats running coordination from the gate? Digitz jacked in to slave the Ricochet sensors? - **PERSUASION DV 15 (Mats):** position Aldecaldos fighters where you want them; otherwise Mateo places them

Then one roll per player: - **Fredrik:** best combat skill vs **DV 15** (his anchor holds) - **Mats:** Tactics, Leadership, or Persuasion vs **DV 13** (Aldecaldos coordination) - **Digitz:** Interface vs **DV 15** (Ricochet slaved + comms-jam on Bicho’s net)

Tally successes (out of 3):

SUCCESSSES	OUTCOME
3	Clean win. No PC injuries. Cati and Reyna’s cousin both fine. Full faction reward
2	Win, messy. One PC takes a Light Wound (their choice). Reyna’s cousin is among the wounded (sets up the Part 5 hook)

SUCSESSES	OUTCOME
1	Pyrrhic. One PC Seriously Wounded. Cati is grazed and shaken (lives). Camp holds but Mateo is grim
0	Camp barely holds. Two PCs Seriously Wounded. Mateo's gratitude is muted — Tía Esmé's family-bond offer in Part 6 requires PERSUASION DV 17 instead of being offered freely

Cati. A 12-year-old Aldecaldos kid runs ammunition during the fight. Optional roleplay beat in the setup minute — do they wave her off, thank her, learn her name? She's brave and she's been doing this since she was eight. Whatever happens to her in the outcome table is the consequence of the dice.

Don Bicho survives regardless. He retreats on a hover-cycle stashed in the wash, vowing return. Future antagonist.

Aftermath: Camp survives. Mateo embraces each of them in turn. Cati gives Fredrik a small steel pendant her mother made. Mateo provides: - Letter of introduction to **Tía Esmé Aldecaldo** in Nueva Costa - A token for **Comandante Castillo** at the border (a Aldecaldos snake-mark coin — Castillo takes the coin, *he doesn't take cash from you*) - Fuel, a swap of supplies, basic mechanical repair on the van - The waystation's brand-of-respect: a small snake tattoo, offered free, on a place of their choosing. **GM Note:** If any player takes it, mark a positive faction standing they can call on once per future adventure

Part 3: La Frontera (The Border)

The old US-Mexico border crossing south of San Ysidro. The Federal infrastructure is rusted out. **Comandante Castillo** runs the checkpoint with about 30 men and a battery of salvaged anti-air. He's not technically a warlord — he was an actual Federal officer who never got the order to abandon his post, so he just kept *operating it*. Now he charges crossing fees.

Arrival.

A line of trucks, motorcycles, and one impossibly old yellow taxi. Castillo's men work the line professionally — a kind of feudal bureaucracy. Forms, fees, vehicle search. The whole operation feels closer to a TSA checkpoint than to a smuggler crossing.

At the Window.

The team reaches Castillo's clerk. Standard interrogation. Vehicle search incoming.

Resolution options:

1. **Mateo's coin.** Hand the snake-mark coin to the clerk. The clerk stops what he's doing. *"One moment, please."* He fetches Castillo personally. Castillo is small, weathered, military-formal. He accepts the coin, *salutes the team* (he respects Mateo), waves them through. Vehicle search canceled. *"Welcome to Mexico, señores. Don't make me a liar for letting you in."*
2. **Bribe.** 5,000 eb gets them through with a perfunctory search. PERSUASION DV 13 to keep the search shallow. Failure: search uncovers the drone coolers, which initiates a separate negotiation (Castillo asks 50,000 eb to let it pass, and *will* fight if refused).
3. **Bluff their way through.** Forged paperwork, corpo cover. PERSUASION DV 17, with -2 if anyone in the party still has obvious chrome-merc presentation. Failure: vehicle search, see #2.
4. **Netrun fake permits.** Castillo's checkpoint runs a sad little local NET arch on the clerk's terminal — Federal-issue, never updated, jacked into the line scanner. Digitz (or any Netrunner) can plant pre-cleared transit permits while the van crawls forward in line. Architecture: 3 floors. Password (DV 8), Wisp (Black ICE, light), File (the permit registry). Net Action DVs as standard. On success, the clerk's scanner pings green, paperwork prints itself, vehicle search waived. *"Huh. You're already cleared. Move along."* On a botched Cloak or a beaten Wisp, the terminal flags an intrusion — Castillo walks out personally and the team has to fall back to coin / bribe / bluff at -2 (he knows something is wrong).
 - **GM Note:** This is a chance for Digitz to actually carry a scene. Run it as a quick 2–3 turn dive, not a full dungeon. If Mats helps with a face-to-face distraction at the window, give Digitz +2 on the Cloak.
5. **Force.** Suicide. Castillo's anti-air takes the van apart at 200m on the south side. *Don't do this.*

GM Note: Most groups will use the coin. If they didn't earn the coin (skipped Part 2's defense) they have to bribe, bluff, or run the NET. The netrun option exists specifically so Digitz has a meaningful play and so groups without persuasion stats still have a clean path.

Part 4: Tijuana

Crossing in. Mexico opens up. The first 20 minutes south of the border feels like a dream sequence — old neon storefronts powered by diesel generators, marigold garlands strung between balconies, three different radio stations bleeding into the van’s speakers, a sky the color of antiseptic. It is not Night City. Night City is *behind*.

Day of the Dead is in three days. The auction is timed for it deliberately — buyers travel for the festival, money moves through the city, and corp security focuses on the wealthier zones. The whole city is in pre-festival mode. Cyber-lucha posters paper every wall. Pan de muerto in every bakery window. A giant inflatable Catrina above the avenida.

The safehouse. Ofelia “Ofi” Castañeda runs a flower shop in Zona Norte with two reinforced apartments above it. The shop is real — she sells real flowers, mostly to real florists, and the cash is laundering cover. The apartments above are her safe-letting business for visiting fixers.

Ofi. Late 30s, dark hair pulled back, perpetual cigarette, doesn’t smile until she decides you’ve earned one. Her Spanish is fluid Tijuanaense and her English is rapid-fire and clinical. She runs the door on her terms.

“Kojo says I should treat you like family. I’m going to do something close to that. The apartment is yours through the auction. The shop downstairs is mine. If you steal a single carnation I will shoot you in the femoral. Bienvenidos.”

The buyer landscape briefing.

Ofi sits the players down with a bottle of mezcal and a hand-drawn diagram. She walks them through the four buyers Kojo identified:

BUYER	REPRESENTS	PAYS IN	OFI’S READ
Doña Esperanza Vargas	Los Curanderos (ripperdoc cartel)	Cash + permanent clinic favor	Reliable. Religious. Means what she says. <i>Will not</i> meet you cold — must earn it through Tuesday’s lucha card
Mr. Vega	Militech cutout (almost certainly)	Cash, a lot of it, + corporate extraction shield	Smooth. Educated. Will know your file. Selling here puts you on Militech’s roster permanently — they call, you answer

BUYER	REPRESENTS	PAYS IN	OFI'S READ
Tía Esmé Aldecaldó	The Aldecaldos Nomad family	Modest cash + deep alliance + a Nomad family bond	Best long-term play. Won't outbid Vega on cash. Will outbid him on <i>what it gets you for the rest of your life</i> . Needs Mateo's letter
Iku Tanaka	Pacific Rim medical conglomerate (claims)	Top dollar, clean transfer, <i>no other terms offered</i>	Slick. <i>Too clean</i> . Ofi doesn't trust him. Won't say why. Won't tell you not to take the meet

How the sale works — Ofi's lecture, listen carefully.

"You don't sell from this apartment. You sell on the floor at Nueva Costa. That is the rule, and it is not my rule, it is the rule of the three syndicates that run the rigs and they will burn anyone who tries to walk a sale around them. The house takes 12% of the cash hammer price, split between the three. That's how we eat. You don't pay it, you bleed."

She breaks it down:

- **The meetings (Wednesday):** Each buyer gets a brief sealed-case inspection — they scan it, weigh it, ask provenance questions. They cannot open it. They cannot match-fire the firmware. They get **90 seconds** under Ofi's eyes. The point is they verify the goods are real
- **The addendum:** Each buyer signs a **non-cash addendum** at the meeting — witnessed by Ofi, real ink, real chop. The clinic, the bond, the extradition shield, whatever they're offering on top of cash. *That's the contract*. It's binding on whichever buyer wins the bid at auction
- **The auction (Thursday):** Open cash bidding on Lot 4 (the sealed pair). Each buyer's bid is "**X cash + my signed addendum**." Players have **seller's discretion** — they choose the winning bid, not necessarily the highest cash number. *They pick the package they want*
- **The 80% floor:** To stop sham closes to friends, syndicate rules require the accepted bid be at least 80% of the highest cash bid on the table. So you can take a lower cash number to grab a richer addendum — but not absurdly lower

"That's why the meetings matter. Cash is cash, you can chase it. The addendum is what you actually buy with the deal. Pay attention to what each one is willing to put their name on."

She lays out the **3-day plan**: - **Day D-2 (Tuesday):** La Lucha Cromada. Curanderos gate. *"Win or lose, fight well. The Doña watches the card herself"* - **Day D-1 (Wednesday):** Buyer meetings around the city. Case inspections + addendum signings. Indicative cash discussed but never locked - **Day D-0 (Thursday):** Helicopter from the seawall at sundown. Auction on Nueva Costa, sundown to midnight. *That is where the deal closes*

Player initiative: They can deviate. They can scout the auction venue early. They can try to meet Doña Esperanza without the lucha (won't work cold — but Mats can establish that he tried). They can spend the morning of Tuesday at the Día de los Muertos parade to soak in the local flavor. The schedule is theirs — but the sale has to land on the floor at Nueva Costa.

GM Note: Lean into atmosphere here. Tijuana should feel as physically different from Night City as you can make it — sun, dust, food smells, color, languages braided together, infrastructure that is *older* and *more human-scale*. Spend time on it. The players will reward it.

Part 5: La Lucha Cromada

Tuesday night. La Plaza Hueso. A converted bullring in central Tijuana. Capacity 4,000, sold out, painted sugar skulls on every column, a brass band that doubles as the entry music for the fighters. Día de los Muertos is two nights away and the whole crowd is already wearing face paint.

Doña Esperanza has reserved a private box on the second tier. She's wearing black, drinking from a small ceramic cup, and watching the card with the focused stillness of someone evaluating cattle.

The Card. Three matches before the main event. Players can mingle, place bets, listen.

STREETWISE/PERSUASION rolls reveal: Reyna Solano “La Viuda” is the biggest star on this card. She wants out of the circuit but the syndicate has her contract. She fights *clean*. Her partners El Padre and El Hijo are veterans, professional, not psychopaths.

The Match. Singles bout, two falls out of three, non-lethal cyberware ruleset (no firearms, no monoblade weapons, no lethal-effect cyberware). **Fredrik** is the fighter in the ring against **La Viuda**. Mats and Digitz work the corner as her opponents' stable will work theirs — *segundos*, cornermen, fixers in tuxedos. **They do not climb the ropes; they hold the gate.**

Crowd payoff: Reyna recognizes Fredrik and Mats when they enter — “*Aldecaldos!*” she shouts to her cornermen, having heard about the camp defense from her cousin. She raises a fist to them across the ring. The crowd reads it as a salute between champions. **Faction goodwill, made physical.**

Fredrik's spotlight. This is built for him. Combat Awareness +5 DMG, Melee Weapon 6, cyberarm slam used as Big Knuckles 3d6 (the Pop-up pistol is banned by ruleset). He's tested in the ring on his own.

The Corner Game. The kayfabe trick — Reyna's stable (El Padre, El Hijo) work ringside, and they *will* try to “interfere” the way every wrestling heel does: a hand on the rope when Fredrik runs for the corner, a thrown chair, El Hijo spitting flashpaste at the canvas when the ref isn't looking, a quiet

shiv pressed into Reyna’s palm between rounds (kayfabe; she will not actually use it). Mats and Digitz are the ones who stop it. **They can also flip it — interfere for Fredrik.** Slip him a chrome upgrade, jam a Sandevistan trigger, rile the crowd into noise that covers a stomp.

The ref is one underpaid man in a striped shirt. He sees what the crowd wants him to see. Most interference will pass — but obvious interference loses the *crowd*, which is what Doña is actually watching.

Round structure (run as 3 narrative rounds, ~3 exchanges each):

ROUND	IN-RING (FREDRIK VS REYNA)	RINGSIDE (MATS + DIGITZ)
1	Establishment. Posturing, crowd work, first exchanges. Reyna tests Fredrik’s reach	El Padre paws at the ropes when Fredrik backs into them. Mats glares him off (PERSUASION/INTIMIDATE DV 13) or shoulder-checks him (BRAWLING DV 13). El Hijo plays to the crowd, no interference yet
2	The wrinkle. La Viuda’s Sandevistan activates for a turn — +3 init, clean shot at Fredrik. She <i>almost</i> uses the monoblade fan — visibly pulls the strike. Ref doesn’t see it. First fall available either way (REF DV 15 to escape a pin)	El Hijo’s flashpaste lights — he’s about to spit it across the canvas under Fredrik’s feet. Digitz can fritz the rig (TECH/Electronics DV 15) to misfire it into El Hijo’s own face. Or Mats can grab El Padre as he tries to slip Reyna a small chrome shiv between rounds (PERCEPTION DV 13 to spot, BRAWLING DV 13 to stop)
3	The closer. Either fighter can take the second fall. If El Hijo’s flashpaste was fritzed, that’s the 1-round visibility chaos beat in their corner instead of Fredrik’s. If not, it hits the canvas and Fredrik fights blind for a round	Mats/Digitz can interfere <i>for</i> Fredrik — slipping him a knux upgrade (DV 15, ref looks away but the crowd notices), spiking the PA so the bell rings on his swing (DV 17), or simply riling the front row into a chant that breaks Reyna’s focus (PERSUASION DV 13). Every “for” interference is a +1 to Fredrik’s next roll but stacks toward a dirty-finish read

Stats (use as guidance, simplified):

FIGHTER	HP	SP	ATTACK	KEY TRAIT
La Viuda (Reyna) — in ring	35	9	Cyberarm 3d6, Sandevistan 1x	Glass cannon. Fast. Won’t actually go lethal

FIGHTER	HP	SP	ATTACK	KEY TRAIT
El Padre — ringside heel	60	14	Cyberarm slam 4d6, grapple specialist	Slow, strong. Hands on the rope. Hard to physically dislodge (Brawling DV 15)
El Hijo del Diablo — ringside heel	40	11	Cyber-foot kicks 3d6, flashpaste 2d6 fire (3m cone)	Theatrical, plays to the crowd. The interference <i>engine</i> — he's the one with the toys

Damage handling: All damage is “tracked” but doesn’t actually reduce HP below 1 — the ref calls submissions and pins on cumulative damage milestones. Run as a narrative-mechanical hybrid; don’t be afraid to fudge for drama. Fredrik cannot die in this match. He can lose face, take chrome scuffs, and earn the crowd’s respect or its boos.

Crowd read (the thing Doña is actually scoring). Track a rough **Crowd dial** — start at neutral, each clean Fredrik strike or escape moves it toward him, each obvious chrome-assist or ringside grapple moves it away. Where the dial ends matters more than who took the second fall.

Outcome: - Clean win (Fredrik finishes on his own merits or with subtle/legal corner-work, crowd dial positive): Crowd erupts. Doña tips her ceramic cup. Handler arrives in 5 min: “*La Doña verá a ustedes mañana. Sus términos.*” Vega approaches that night. Reyna seeks them out after —

wants to talk to them later, alone - **Dirty win (Fredrik wins but the crowd saw the chrome, dial negative):** Curanderos handler arrives anyway but cooler: “*La Doña dice que tienen estilo, pero no honor.*” B-list pricing on Doña’s offer. Vega approaches *more* warmly — he respects the result over the optics - **Loss (clean):** Crowd respects them. Doña handler: “*La Doña dice que tienen valor.*

Mañana a las tres.” B-list Doña meet still happens. Vega still approaches. Reyna still seeks them out - **Loss (dirty — Fredrik loses and they were caught cheating):** Doña does not send a handler. They have lost the Curanderos as a buyer. Vega still approaches but quotes a lower opening offer. Down to two buyers (Tía Esmé, Tanaka)

Mr. Vega’s approach. After the bout, in the cooldown corridor under the stands. A man in a linen suit, no visible chrome, no obvious security but *something is wrong with the air around him*. He extends a card. “Mr. Vega. I represent interested parties from the north. I was given a recommendation, and I confirmed it tonight. May we speak tomorrow?” Hands them a coordinates card for a rooftop bar. “Five o’clock. Just the three of you. Pay for your own drinks; I will not insult you with hospitality.” Then he is gone.

Part 6: The Buyer Tour

Wednesday. Players run their meetings.

This part is roleplay-heavy. Three scenes total — the first stacks Doña Esperanza and Vega together at a public plaza, then a private cantina meet with Tía Esmé, then dinner with Tanaka. **Ofelia accompanies them to every meeting** with the sealed case in a hardshell messenger bag, and *she* runs the 90-second inspection each buyer is allowed. The players don't carry the case themselves — that's not what they're paying her 12% for.

At each meeting, three things happen: 1. Inspection (90 seconds). Buyer scans, weighs, examines the seal. Asks 1-3 provenance questions — firmware lock state, lab origin, has it been powered on. Ofi enforces the clock. *No buyer is allowed to open the case.* **2. The addendum is signed.** Each buyer puts their non-cash term on paper — real ink, witnessed by Ofi. Doña's clinic-for-life, Tía's family bond, Vega's extradition shield. Binding on whoever wins the auction bid **3. Indicative cash discussed.** Each buyer states a *range* they're prepared to bid in. Not locked. The cash is the part that floats — that's what the auction floor is for

Each buyer will try to learn what the others offered (Mats picks up on this immediately, Human Perception), and each may raise the *addendum* once they realize they're in a competitive bid. Cash they'll save for the room.

Meet 1: Doña Esperanza & Mr. Vega — Plaza Santa Cecilia (public, two-at-once)

Location: Plaza Santa Cecilia, a major pre-festival altar plaza in central TJ. Marigolds, photographs, the smell of pan de muerto, half-finished parade floats. Both buyers are *publicly* here — Doña Esperanza is hosting a Curanderos charity clinic tent (free check-ups for the neighborhood, the Día PR play of the year), and a Militech-flagged parade float is being readied two corners away, with Vega himself overseeing setup from a folding chair under a marigold awning.

Ofelia warned the team: *"They'll both be there. They both know you're coming. Don't get cornered in either tent — stay on the plaza floor, keep moving."*

Run this as **one ~25-30 minute scene** where the players shuttle between the two buyers, each pitch happening in earshot or eyeline of the other. The competitive pressure is the whole point of stacking them.

Doña Esperanza intercepts first, near the altar. Ofi opens the messenger bag. Doña's ripperdoc — a woman with chrome on her hands and a holstered scanner — does the inspection. Three questions: *"Has it been powered? Is the seal Voss's work or someone after her? What does the firmware lock say to a Curanderos handshake?"* Ninety seconds, clean. The seal closes.

Then Doña sits with the players on a marigold-lined bench.

“Both units. I do not need to be a monopolist — I need to be the buyer your community remembers fondly. I’ll bid in the room. The addendum I will put my name to today is permanent surgical privileges at any Curanderos clinic, for the three of you, for life. That is forever. The cash I will fight for on the floor; expect me to open around 140,000 eb.”

She signs the addendum. Ofi witnesses.

Read: Genuine. The “permanent clinic” terms are real and traceable through Curanderos’s reputation. The *safest* buyer.

Addendum upgrades (Mats): - DV 15: Curanderos-installed mid-grade cyberware (~5k eb value) for each PC, written in - DV 17: Curanderos militia protection if Arasaka comes asking, written in

Vega’s staffer intercepts as the players step away from the tent and gestures them toward the float. Vega meets them in the shade of the awning — Fredrik AWARENESS DV 15: a sniper team is set up across the boulevard, not for the players, for Vega’s safety. Standard practice. A man with a corporate-grade scanner does Vega’s inspection. He asks one question: *“Original Arasaka serials still readable on the chassis, or scrubbed?”* The answer matters to him; he watches the players’ faces, not the case.

“My principals are very interested. On the floor we’ll be aggressive on cash — expect 150,000-200,000 eb depending on the room. My addendum on paper today is a non-extradition guarantee in Militech-aligned territories. If Arasaka issues a bounty on you, no one we hold a line with will honor it.”

He signs. Ofi witnesses.

The catch: He never says “Militech,” but his speech, his protection detail, his briefcase, the man’s posture all say it. Selling here means: - They become *assets* on Militech’s books — not enemies, but people Militech can call on - They never appear on the payroll, but they will be expected to receive Militech calls in the future - If Arasaka ever comes back at them, Militech *might* help — and now it’s *contractual*

Addendum upgrades: - DV 15: Add a small Militech extraction-team standby for one future emergency (one-time use, written in) - DV 17: Add a Militech-grade safehouse rotation in three Pacific Rim cities

Cross-pressure (the reason they’re stacked). Doña has a clean sightline of Vega’s awning across the plaza, and vice versa. Each is *watching* the other sign their addendum. Mats can leverage this: - **PERSUASION DV 15:** Either buyer adds one extra clause to their addendum on the spot, *because the other one is watching*. Works once per buyer - **PERSUASION DV 17:** Get one buyer to telegraph a higher indicative cash range — useful intel for the auction floor

Tanaka is not here. Día de los Muertos PR isn't his crowd, and he'd be remembered.

Meet 2: Tía Esmé Aldecaldos (Aldecaldos)

Location: Cantina La Serpiente, in a Nomad-owned compound on the eastern edge of TJ. Players need Mateo's letter to get past the door. Inside: bandana-and-leather, kids running between tables, a band playing norteño-electric.

Tía Esmé is in her 50s, lean, gray-streaked braid, snake-mark coin on a chain. She receives them at a corner table with two bowls of birria. Ofi sets the case on a third chair. Tía Esmé's tech — a kid with a scarred face and good hands — does the ninety-second pass. He asks one question: *"Will it talk to a Nomad rig that wasn't built by Arasaka?"* He's checking for proprietary lockout.

"Mateo says you defended his people. That is rare. Most of the time a stranger 'defends our people' to mean they fired their weapon in our direction and called it brotherhood. You actually fought. That changes the conversation."

"The Aldecaldos want the droneware. We want it because every year more of us die to corps who think we are road kill. We want a weapon that puts the fear on the other side of the equation. We cannot pay what Militech pays. We can pay what alliance pays."

Her addendum (signed today): - **Permanent Aldecaldos family bond** for the three of them — every Aldecaldos waystation, on every road in the Americas, becomes a place where they sleep safe, eat free, and can call for backup - A position with the family if any of them ever wants it (relevant for long-term character arcs) - **One clause she writes in:** they don't tell *anyone* it was the Aldecaldos who bought

Her cash: *"I will bid 50-70,000 eb on the floor. I will not chase Militech's number. I refuse, on principle. If you want the bond, you accept the lower cash. That is how alliance works."*

Read: True. The family bond is the kind of thing that pays out for the rest of their lives. The cash is lousy by comparison to Vega's offer. The bond is priceless.

Addendum upgrades: Tía Esmé won't raise the cash. She'll deepen the bond if Mats impresses her (DV 15: a personal stake from her own clan, written in; DV 17: a kuvasz-sized cyber-mastiff trained as a guardian, given to whichever PC she likes most)

Meet 3: Iku Tanaka (the trap)

Location: A private dining room at a sushi place near the seawall. White tablecloths. Quiet. Tanaka is alone. Mid-40s, Japanese, perfect posture, a single subtle neural-link port behind his ear. He has no technician — *he* does the inspection himself, with a handheld scanner pulled from a leather portfolio. He asks no provenance questions. He just *looks* at the case, scans it, hands it back.

“I represent a Pacific Rim medical foundation. We have a particular interest in advanced neural-bridging cyberware. On the floor we will be aggressive — expect 180,000 eb cash, possibly higher. Payable in immediate clean transfer at hammer.”

Ofi prompts: *“And your addendum, señor?”*

Tanaka smiles, slightly. *“None. We prefer a clean transaction. Cash, transfer, no further entanglement. Discretion is its own value.”*

The bid-shape tell (free, no roll required). Every other buyer has put a non-cash term on paper. Tanaka refuses to. *Every real buyer wants a relationship.* He is buying a transaction. **A sharp player at the table should notice this on its own** — flag it explicitly to whoever is paying attention. This is the cheapest tell in the adventure and the design wants players to clock it.

Read on Tanaka — Human Perception checks build a richer picture: - DV 13: He is extremely good at small talk. He has memorized details about each player from somewhere - DV 15: His “Pacific Rim medical foundation” doesn’t show up in any of the searches Digitz can run during dinner. Nothing. *Nothing at all.* A real entity would have some footprint - DV 17: His Japanese is too good to be a Pacific Rim general dialect — it’s *Tokyo metropolitan, Arasaka corporate dialect.* This is a tell only Fredrik might catch, given his Japanese-1 background skill, or only if Mats has been listening for it - DV 19: There is a very small Arasaka logo embossed inside the band of his watch. Visible only when he tilts his wrist to drink. Lucky catch only

He is Arasaka counterintelligence. He is not here to buy. He is here to *learn the meet location, learn who else is bidding, and arrange a Section-9 takedown at the auction venue.* The no-addendum bid shape is consistent with this — he never expected the deal to actually close.

If players signal they’re onto him: Tanaka is polite, finishes dinner, leaves the bill. He has now *confirmed* that the team is alert — the Section-9 auction-night raid will be heavier and better prepared (add 2 troopers, see Part 7).

If players don’t catch him: He walks away pleased. The auction-night attack still happens, but the players are unprepared for it.

Part 7: Costa Muerta (The Auction)

Thursday at sundown. The seawall helipad. A converted Sea King helicopter waits for the team. Ofelia is the door agent. Each buyer's representatives board at the same time — Doña Esperanza in person with a single bodyguard, a Militech junior staffer on Vega's behalf (Vega himself stays in TJ — *"I'll be reachable"*), Tía Esmé with two armed Aldecaldos cousins, Iku Tanaka alone, and a half-dozen unknown other buyers from across the Pacific Rim and Latin America.

Pre-flight: Ofelia hands the players a hardcase. *"Two units. Sealed by me, witnessed by Doña Esperanza when she signed in. Don't lose this case. Don't open it before the auction. And god help you if you spill anything wet on it."*

The flight: 35 minutes, west into the Pacific. Sundown over the ocean. The rigs come up like a constellation rising from below — strings of light on a dozen platforms anchored together with gangways and cable.

Nueva Costa.

Picture a daisy-chain of converted Pemex platforms, lashed together with bridges, ramps, and rope, and connected by a central platform that hosts the **Costa Muerta auction floor**. Each rig is a different fiefdom: a ripperdoc rig, a data-broker rig, a market rig, a residential rig for the workers, and the central platform that hosts the *Salón de la Casa Muerta* — the auction hall, an elegant converted helicopter hangar lined with skulls and marigolds for the Día festival.

The Hosts. Three syndicates run Nueva Costa jointly — a Curanderos-allied ripperdoc cartel, a data-broker collective called **La Red**, and an Aldecaldos-adjacent Nomad maritime family known as **Los Marinos**. None of the three syndicates are *armed enough* to dominate the others, which is why everyone tolerates the arrangement. This will become important.

House rules: - All firearms checked at the central platform armory on arrival. PCs get one concealed sidearm each (house norm; can't enforce *zero* weapons among professional buyers) - The Ricochet stays on the helicopter. *Cannot* be brought to the auction floor - Internal disputes are handled by **the Pacers** — a small contingent of armored peacekeepers from each syndicate, ~12 total, who patrol the central platform. They don't break up bidding disputes. They break up shootings - Auction lots are presented one at a time. Bidding is open. The seller (the players) sit in a sponsor box - **The house takes 12% of the cash hammer price**, split between the three syndicates. Non-cash addendums are not taxable (the syndicates cannot tax a family bond or a clinic favor) - **Seller's discretion:** the seller chooses the winning bid, not the auctioneer. The accepted bid must be at least **80% of the highest cash bid on the table** (anti-collusion floor). So players can take a lower cash number to grab a richer addendum — but not absurdly lower - Failed lots return to the seller, minus a 5,000 eb listing fee

Auction Mechanics.

There are five lots tonight. The droneware is **Lot 4**, sold as a sealed pair — Ofelia made this a non-negotiable house rule when she sealed the case (*“they go together or they don’t go at all; I’m not selling halves of a thing that should never have left a lab”*). Other lots include: a militec-grade dataset, a Petrochem core sample (chemistry secret), some other dark-end items. None of those are the players’ problem.

The bid format. Each buyer who signed an addendum at Wednesday’s meetings will, when their turn comes, state their bid as: *“X cash, plus my addendum on file.”* Players track these on a side card — Ofi keeps the actual ledger. At the close they pick which package they prefer (subject to the 80% floor).

Pre-bid setup: Before Lot 4, the auctioneer (a woman in a black-and-gold mask, mic’d to the room) introduces the lot. The room sees what they’re buying — both units in a single glass case, paired. Doña Esperanza nods slightly. Tía Esmé’s bodyguard whispers something to her. Vega’s staffer is taking notes on a paper pad. **Tanaka is not there.**

That is the first red flag.

The Attack.

Round 1. Mid-bidding on Lot 4. The lights in the Salón flicker once. Then twice. The auctioneer pauses. Then the lights go out completely.

Emergency lighting kicks in — dim red. The room is on its feet. Someone is shouting. A muffled *bang* outside.

What’s happening: A small Arasaka Section-9 team — six operators in light EVA-style suits — has just boarded the residential rig from a stealth submersible. They’ve cut the auction floor’s external comms and they’re pushing toward the Salón to take both droneware units and exfiltrate. Tanaka is on the sub coordinating. He never came to the auction because he was always going to seize the lots, not bid on them.

Round 2-3. First gunfire from outside. The Pacers respond — three of them down in the first volley. The Section-9 team is *good*. The Salón doors are reinforced but not magic.

Player options:

1. **Defend the Salón.** Hold the auction floor. The other buyers will fight alongside them if asked properly — Doña Esperanza has her bodyguard, Tía Esmé's cousins, Vega's staffer with a hidden Sandevistan-Heavy Pistol combo. All in, the players have +4 allies in the room. The Section-9 team is 6 strong and very, very good.
2. **Run with the case.** Take the drone-ware and bolt — out a service hatch, across the gangways to the helicopter rig. Section-9 will follow. Running fight across multiple platforms.

Section-9 Team:

TYPE	SP	HP	WEAPON	NOTES
Section-9 Operator (x5)	15	45	SMG 4d6, Smart Frag Grenades, Sandevistan	Coordinated. Professional. Will not freelance — every action serves the team mission
Section-9 Team Lead	17	55	Tech-rifle 5d6, full neural interface, micro-drone scout	Will sacrifice ops to grab the case

Tanaka stays on the submersible the entire engagement, coordinating by radio. He is not reachable from the auction floor or the gangways. When the Section-9 team breaks or fails the grab, he pulls the sub and is gone.

The Salón Defense.

The Salón is an ideal *defensive* space — one main entry, two service entries, no windows. The challenge is that *the entire auction is inside*. Twenty buyers, ten staff, the auctioneer, the band. The Section-9 team will frag grenade through the doors if not deterred.

- **Doña Esperanza** is unflappable. She crosses herself, draws a chrome derringer, and posts up behind a column. *“Hijos, you defend my new property. I’ll pay the bonus.”*
- **Tía Esmé** is in her element. Calling tactical orders to her cousins. Locks eyes with Fredrik: *“Mátalos.”*
- **Vega’s staffer** flips a coin: doesn’t fight unless personally engaged, in which case he is *terrifying* (4d6 Heavy Pistol with smart link).
- **The Pacers** — the surviving 8 — set up the second perimeter at the service corridor. The players can coordinate with them: PERSUASION DV 13 to integrate. If integrated, the Pacers add 3d6 Heavy Pistol fire per round at the operators’ approach.

Wave structure: - Round 1: Lights out, frag at the main door (Players + Pacers absorb. Door SP 15) - Round 2-3: Section-9 breaches main door. Two operators in. Players + Doña + Tía's cousins respond. Aim for one Section-9 operator down by end of round 3 - Round 4-5: Section-9 tries the service corridor. Vega's staffer reveals his Sandevistan and *delivers*. One more operator down - Round 6-7: The Team Lead leads a final push directly for the case. This is the most dangerous round — frag grenades into the bidder section, Sandevistan-enhanced charge. Aim for someone PC-adjacent to get hurt - Round 8+: If Section-9 has lost 4, they retreat. If they've lost the Team Lead, they retreat immediately. If the players are losing, *Doña Esperanza herself* takes a 6d6 shot to defend the case — she lives, but it's a near thing. *She remembers who paid that debt.*

Run with the case option.

Fastest combat — about 4 rounds of running fight across gangways. Players make it to the helicopter rig, helicopter has been kept hot by the pilot (Ofelia's standing order: "*Engines running until everyone is back or everyone is dead*"). Liftoff. Section-9 hits one operator with a tagging dart that lets them track the chopper for ~30 minutes — but the chopper is fast and over open water. Player choice: dump the tag (find it, AWARENESS DV 15) or accept Tanaka knows where they landed.

Resolution of the Auction.

Assuming the players survive Section-9 and protect the case:

The auction *resumes*. The room knows they just watched a corporate raid get repelled by the sellers of the lot in question. **This is worth bidding for.** A unit that the Arasaka Special Recovery Division wants this badly is a unit worth owning. Indicative cash ranges firm up and climb — the post-raid risk premium pushes every buyer's number up by roughly 20%.

Final bids on Lot 4 (typical, after the raid risk premium):

BUYER	CASH BID	ADDENDUM ON FILE
Doña Esperanza	160,000 eb	Curanderos clinic-for-life (+ any DV 15/17 upgrades signed Wednesday)
Tía Esmé Aldecaldó	65,000 eb	Aldecaldos family bond (+ any DV 15/17 upgrades)
Mr. Vega's staffer (phone-cleared)	220,000 eb	Militech non-extradition shield (+ any signed upgrades)
Quiet Petrochem rep (optional cameo, no addendum)	230,000 eb	None — clean cash, like Tanaka

The 80% floor in practice: Vega's 220k or Petrochem's 230k sets the cash ceiling. The lowest acceptable bid on the table is 80% of that — so ~184k if Vega tops, ~184k if Petrochem cameos. **Tía Esmé's 65k is technically below the floor** — to accept her bond addendum, the players must either negotiate her cash up (PERSUASION DV 17 in real-time on the floor; she'll grudgingly push to ~150k if Mats lands it because the Section-9 raid just *proved* the Aldecaldos need this) or negotiate the syndicates' floor down (PERSUASION DV 17 with the auctioneer — invokes the Section-9 raid as cause for an exception)

Seller's call. Players pick the winning package. They can: - Take **Doña** (160k cash, clinic-for-life) — safest long-term - Take **Vega** (220k cash, extradition shield) — most cash, you're a Militech asset - Take **Tía Esmé** (negotiated 150k cash + family bond) — best Nomad-flavored future, hardest to land mechanically - Take **Petrochem** (230k clean) — most cash, no relationship, *and the room will read it as repeating Tanaka's mistake*

Net to players (after 12% house cut on cash, before any final-table negotiation): - Doña: $160k \times 0.88 = 140,800 \text{ eb} + \text{clinic for life}$ - Vega: $220k \times 0.88 = 193,600 \text{ eb} + \text{extradition shield}$ - Tía (if negotiated up to 150k): $150k \times 0.88 = 132,000 \text{ eb} + \text{family bond}$ - Petrochem: $230k \times 0.88 = 202,400 \text{ eb, no relationship}$

Final-table negotiation tools (after the winning bid is chosen, before the hammer): - PERSUASION DV 13: extract a "you owe me a favor" from the winner, on top of the contract - PERSUASION DV 15: get a non-disclosure pact (the winner doesn't say who they bought from) - PERSUASION DV 17: get a Pacers stand-down on any future attempt to interfere with the players in Nueva Costa's reach (long-term — they can come back here safely)

Part 8: Aftermath

The helicopter lifts at midnight. The auction is closing, the auctioneer is taking a deep breath, the Pacers are cleaning up bodies on the gangways. Three Section-9 operators are alive and prisoner; the Team Lead is dead. Tanaka pulled the submersible during the firefight and is gone — bound for whichever Arasaka safehouse rinses corporate-mascot counterintel agents.

Cash situation (typical outcome): - 100,000-250,000 eb in liquid funds, depending on negotiation - Curanderos clinic-for-life standing (if sold to Doña) - Aldecaldos family bond (if sold to Tía Esmé) - Militech roster entry (if sold to Vega) - Droneware is **off the table** — both units sold, sealed case handed over at auction close. The heat lifts because the units are gone. Don't second-guess this; the adventure ends clean

Faction post-state: - **Doña Esperanza Vargas:** Strong ally if she got a unit. Owes one if she didn't bid high enough - **Tía Esmé Aldecaldo:** Strong ally if she got a unit. Strong ally regardless if Mateo's letter was used well. Aldecaldos family bond unlocked - **Mr. Vega / Militech:** Asset relationship if he

got a unit. Cold neutrality if outbid - **Iku Tanaka / Arasaka:** Hostile, but smaller-scale than before. Section 9 took a serious operational loss; replacing this unit is expensive. They'll back off for a while - **Lazard:** Background only. Kojo passes word two days later: Lazard's internal audit was suspended; he was "reassigned" to an off-grid Arasaka facility in the Pacific Northwest. Translation: he's been deniably retired. The arc ends here — but his name has shape now, a *case file* shape in Arasaka's history - **The Mole:** The Trauma Team van on the border was confirmed. The Mole is alive and exfiltrated. They will not surface again for a long time - **Kojo:** Stronger than ever. He gets 10% of the take. He sends them a handwritten thank-you note via Ofelia. *He has never sent a handwritten anything in his life* - **Ofelia:** Friendly contact for any future Tijuana operations - **Reyna Solano "La Viuda":** Free agent. Won her bout. Sent the players a small painted cyber-mask as a gift. *"For when you next come south."*

The Day of the Dead.

The players spend the morning of Friday, November 2, on Nueva Costa as the syndicates clean up. By afternoon they're back in Tijuana. By evening they are walking through a massive Día de los Muertos parade in central TJ — face paint, marigolds, music, families remembering their dead.

Quiet beat. Fredrik stops at a small altar that has been set up in a corner of the plaza, looks at the photographs of strangers laid out in marigold petals. He has not put up an altar for anyone in a long time. He should think about that.

Mats buys flowers. Digitz, the GMPC, calls his mentor.

PLAYER HANDOUTS

Voss's Menu – Cyberware

Tanaka's Fish Market, back-room clinic. Dr. Voss installs up to three pieces in one sitting before the convoy leaves at dusk.

For Fredrik

ITEM	COST
Subdermal Armor	1,000 eb
Big Knux	100 eb
Pain Editor	1,000 eb
Smartgun Link	1,000 eb
Cybereye TeleOptics	1,000 eb
Kerenzikov	1,000 eb

For Mats

ITEM	COST
Skinweave (premium)	500 eb
Tactile Boost	500 eb
Aarmorjack Businesswear (SP 13)	2,000 eb
Personal AI Driver Interface	2,000 eb
Cyberdeck (basic)	1,000 eb

For Digitz

ITEM	COST
Cybermodem upgrade (top-shelf)	5,000 eb
Extra Interface Plugs	200 eb
Sandevistan	1,000 eb
Two combat/utility programs	~1,000 eb

ITEM	COST
Subdermal Pocket	500 eb

Kojo's Garage – Vehicles

Walled compound behind a strip mall in Watson. Clean paperwork, all of it.

Main Vehicle — pick one

VEHICLE	SPEED	SP	HP	COST
Cargo Van (reinforced, firing slits, smuggler compartments)	5	15	50	Free (brokerage)
Sedan (sleek corpo four-door, tinted glass, shell-company plates)	7	11	30	25,000 eb

Side Vehicle — for Fredrik

VEHICLE	SPEED	SP	HP	COST
Roadbike (off-road model, no remote anything, clean plate)	8	0	25	12,000 eb